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Abstract: This paper offers an analysis of the observation that stripping in non-coordinate structures, such as comparatives and temporal adverbials, does not permit sprouted remnants (i.e., remnants not paired with an overt correlate). I argue that this ultimately reflects an inability to recover a suitable antecedent for ellipsis. In brief, it is because implicit arguments fail to offer a suitable antecedent that sprouted stripping requires the accommodation of a Question Under Discussion. The failure to accommodate such an antecedent specifically in the context of non-coordinate structures is a consequence of the Not-At-Issue status of their content relative to the Question Under Discussion. Accounting for the acceptability of standard sprouting in all domains requires that antecedents may also be recovered from previously uttered content in the discourse. Thus, while the analysis aligns with previous research proposing that antecedents can be accommodated by recovering implicit question meanings, it also requires that there be some degree of flexibility in how antecedents are recovered.

Keywords: ellipsis, stripping, sprouting, recoverability, accommodation

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1 Introduction

The ability to elide some portion of an utterance is constrained by, among other things, the ability to recover the meaning or the content of the ellipsis site. This requirement can be referred to as the Recoverability condition on ellipsis, adapting terminology from [Katz & Postal \(1964\)](#).

Theories regarding the nature of the Recoverability condition have typically been built to find an antecedent for an ellipsis site in one particular domain. The traditional view, which is defended in [Hankamer & Sag \(1976\)](#), and much subsequent work, requires that the antecedent be found within previously spoken content. This provides a way to understand the contrast between the instances of “stripping” in (1) and (2) below, which have been adapted from [Hankamer & Sag 1976:409](#).

(1) *Context : Kayla produces a recorder and plays Margaritaville.*

A: #Nice, and probably on the accordion.

(2) A: Listen, Kayla can play *Margaritaville* on the recorder.

B: Nice, and probably on the accordion.

The intuition is that the contribution made by speaker A in (1) is infelicitous. The reason, the idea goes, is that the discourse does not explicitly provide the material that is intended to supply the interpretation for the elided content. On the other hand, the same ellipsis construction as a response from speaker B is possible in (2). This is because the initial contribution by speaker A provides recoverable antecedent material for B to fill in the meaning that *probably Kayla can play Margaritaville on the accordion*.

The literature on ellipsis has catalogued a significant amount of data that is problematic for this straightforward approach to recoverability, however. There are many cases in which the previously spoken discourse does not contain something with the content or meaning that is intuitively interpreted in the ellipsis site.¹

One response to this issue is to refine the Identity condition on ellipsis, the requirement that the recovered antecedent and the ellipsis site be sufficiently similar. Relaxing the extent to which an antecedent must match the content or meaning of the elided material could make it possible to accept imperfect antecedents. Another response, which is not mutually exclusive with the previous one, is to propose that the antecedent for an ellipsis site is in fact not recovered from previously spoken content. Ellipsis sites might be resolved via pragmatic strategies that don’t make reference

¹The literature abounds with relevant examples. A few of the more familiar instances and some of the representative studies include sloppy anaphora ([Ross 1967](#), [Sag 1976](#), [Williams 1977](#)), split antecedents ([Webber 1978](#)), voice mismatches ([Hardt 1993](#), [Merchant 2013](#), [Sailor 2014](#)), vehicle change ([Fiengo & May 1994](#)), sloppy VP-ellipsis ([Hardt 1999](#), [Schwarz 2000](#), [Tomioka 2008](#)), fragments responses ([Stainton 2006](#), [Merchant 2004](#), [Progovac 2013](#), [Weir 2014a](#)), and exophoric ellipsis ([Miller & Pullum 2013](#)). See also [Lipták 2015](#) and the references provided.

to spoken content and are independently employed for the resolution of proforms. This is a position that might be most familiar from the research by [Hardt \(1993, 1999\)](#) and [Kehler \(2000\)](#).

Yet another response to such issues seeks a middle ground that allows some degree of flexibility in the recovery of an antecedent for ellipsis. For such approaches, an antecedent might be recoverable from previously spoken content. Alternatively, an antecedent might be found in some content that, although implicit in the discourse, can also be recovered for the satisfaction of ellipsis. Adopting terminology from [Fox \(1999, 2000\)](#), this represents cases of antecedent accommodation. Of course, accommodation must come with some limits in order to avoid problems of overgeneration. For [Fox \(2000\)](#), accommodation is limited to content that is entailed by an utterance in the discourse along with any of its presuppositions. This idea has been extended or recast in subsequent literature that includes [Johnson 2012](#), [van Craenenbroeck 2013](#), [Thoms 2015](#), [Barros & Kotek 2019](#), and [Stockwell 2024](#).

An influential alternative for accommodation proposes that an antecedent for ellipsis can be recovered from a salient, possibly implicit, question meaning in the discourse. This idea has been applied productively in the domain of sluicing ([Ginzburg & Sag 2001](#), [AnderBois 2011](#), [Barros 2014](#), [Griffiths 2019b](#)), fragment answers to questions ([Reich 2007](#), [Weir 2014a](#), [Jacobson 2016](#)), and sloppy VP-ellipsis ([Kehler 2015](#)). The relevant constraints on this type of accommodation can then be made to follow from coherent discourse relations.

The goal of the present manuscript is to extend a flexible view of recoverability that permits the accommodation of implicit question meanings to examples of stripping like in (3):

- (3) a. Kim was reading **the article** and probably ~~Kim was reading the novel~~.
 b. Kim was reading and probably ~~Kim was reading the novel~~.²

In the examples above, the “remnant” of ellipsis *the novel* may or may not be paired with an overt “correlate” *the article*. In the later case, the remnant is said to have “sprouted” from the ellipsis site. I will propose that stripping is permitted on the promise of recovering an antecedent either from the spoken content of an utterance or from a possibly implicit question meaning that can be accommodated in the discourse, which we will model in terms of the Question Under Discussion (QUD; [Büring 2003](#), [Roberts 2012](#)). The in-principle flexibility in the recovery of an antecedent for ellipsis, we will see, is an expected property of the focus-based redundancy condition proposed in [Rooth 1992a,b](#).

This picture of recoverability, accommodation, and identity will allow for an account of the contrast between the pair of examples in (3) and the pair of comparative constructions shown below in (4):

²I will adopt the convention using ~~strikethrough~~ text to indicate elided content.

- (4) a. Kim was reading **the article** more carefully than ~~Kim was reading the novel~~.
 b. *Kim was reading more carefully than ~~Kim was reading the novel~~.

Section 2 will review some of the previous literature that converges on the idea that the phrasal comparatives in (4) are targeted by an application of the same stripping operation that generates the examples in (3). Granted that this is the case, it must be explained why sprouting becomes unacceptable in a comparative clause.

I will argue that sprouted stripping represents an instance in which the spoken material of an utterance fails to provide an antecedent for ellipsis. More specifically, implicit arguments do not contribute to a suitable antecedent for licensing ellipsis in the cases above (see also [Stockwell 2020, 2024](#), [Overfelt 2024](#); cf. [Fortin 2007, 2011](#), [Barros 2014](#), [Barros & Kotek 2019](#), and others). This means that, while there is spoken material in (3a) and (4a) to provide antecedents for the elided content, sprouting must rely on the QUD for the purpose of accommodating and recovering a suitable antecedent.

It is the reliance on the accommodation of a QUD antecedent that will allow us to distinguish between the constructions above. I will propose and capitalize on a difference in the At-Issue status of the content contained in each of the above constructions relative to the QUD ([Simons et al. 2010](#), [Tonhauser 2012](#)). It is because the content of the comparative clause is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD that it will not be possible to recover a QUD as an antecedent.³ Consequently, in the case of (4b) specifically, there is no suitable antecedent provided by spoken content of the utterance nor is it possible to felicitously accommodate a QUD as an antecedent. Sprouted stripping, therefore, cannot be licensed in a comparative clause.

As noted, immediately below in section 2 we will begin working toward this analysis by providing some of the relevant background on the syntax of stripping, both in coordinate structures and in comparative clauses. Section 3 will introduce in more detail the issue of sprouting as well as the relevant contrast found between pairs of examples like (3) and (4). We will also spend some time considering a number of alternative approaches that would make it possible to avoid antecedent accommodation. It will be argued that these available alternatives, while suitable for blocking sprouting, do not predict the contrast between the constructions at hand. This will motivate the need for an analysis that sensitive to some operative difference between coordination structures and comparative structures.

In section 4 I will argue that the operative difference between these two domains is the At-Issueness of their content relative to the QUD. We will appeal to widely-used diagnostics proposed by [Tonhauser \(2012\)](#) to support the claim that the content of a second conjunct is At-Issue with respect to the QUD ([Bach 1999](#), [Potts 2005](#)). The same diagnostics indicate that the content of a

³We will take care to reiterate in what follows that the claim is not that comparative constructions are QUD Not-At-Issue. It is the content embedded inside the *than*-clause of comparatives that is found to be Not-At-Issue.

comparative clause, on the other hand, is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD. Section 5 presents in more detail the analysis that was sketched above. This analysis operates under the hypothesis that sprouting is dependent on the accommodation of a QUD but anaphoricity to the QUD is gated by At-Issue-ness. As noted, these prove to be conflicting requirements on sprouting in comparative clauses, but not on sprouting in coordinate constructions.

I will also attempt to extend this analysis in section 6 to two additional domains that have previously been analyzed as a target for stripping. I argue that here too the inability to sprout a remnant coincides with a lack of relevance to the QUD. The paper concludes in section 7 by reviewing some of the major results of the investigation and pointing to possible directions for future research.

2 Background on stripping

2.1 Canonical stripping

Stripping, as it is described by [Hankamer & Sag \(1976\)](#), is a phenomenon whereby some content of a clause is omitted under identity with the content of a preceding clause. The result is typically a single “remnant” constituent that is spared deletion alongside a particle or adverbial element. Examples like those below, with remnants in bold text, exemplify the construction.⁴

- (5) a. Jane gave presents to JOHN but she seldom gave presents to GEOFF.
b. Jane gave presents to JOHN but seldom **to GEOFF**. ([Lobeck 1995:27](#), (71a))
- (6) a. John read EL QUIJOTE but he did not read HAMLET.
b. John read EL QUIJOTE but not **HAMLET**. ([Depiante 2000:104](#), (4b))

The major analytical puzzle of stripping constructions is how the second conjunct is reduced to just the remnant material. I would direct the reader to the discussions presented in [Depiante 2000](#), [Kolokonte 2008](#), [Konietzko 2016](#) and [Johnson 2019](#) for an overview of the extensive empirical and theoretical landscape of stripping. Much of this literature has operated under the belief that ellipsis, in one of its various conceptions (see [Merchant 2019](#)), is responsible for rendering material unspoken.⁵ Ellipsis-based approaches provide a straightforward way to make sense of [Hankamer & Sag’s \(1976\)](#) observation that stripping, at some level, is anaphoric to the parts of the discourse in which appears.

⁴Stripping, like other instances of ellipsis, is closely tied to the focus structure of an utterance ([Tancredi 1992](#), [Rooth 1992b](#)). I will use SMALL-CAPS to indicate the placement of the pitch accent associated with focus.

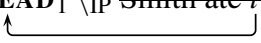
⁵A family of alternative proposals that do not appeal to ellipsis involve what [Hudson \(1976\)](#) refers to “Conjunct Postposing.” Though varied in the precise implementation, the idea is that remnant material is postposed rightward from an initial clause (see also [Ross 1967](#) and [Reinhart 1991](#)).

Ellipsis-based approaches raise questions, however, regarding the ability to omit strings that do not obviously correspond to syntactic constituents, something antithetical to some of the earliest studies of ellipsis (e.g., [Sag 1976](#)). As [Johnson \(2019\)](#) observes of example (7) below, the material omitted from the second conjunct would form a discontinuous string of categories:

(7) Smith ate SEAFOOD yesterday and ~~Smith ate BREAD~~ yesterday too.

This apparent non-constituent ellipsis can be understood to arise by way of the Move-and-Delete approach to ellipsis that has been proposed for both sluicing and fragment utterances ([Ross 1969](#), [Merchant 2001, 2004](#), et seq.). This approach to stripping, which finds extensive support from [Jayaseelan \(1990\)](#), [Depiante \(2000\)](#) and [Kolokonte \(2008\)](#), proposes that the example in (7) in fact has the derivation and representation presented in (8).⁶

(8) [CP Smith ate SEAFOOD yesterday] and [CP **BREAD**₁ <IP ~~Smith ate *t*₁ yesterday~~ > too]



The remnant constituent *bread* in the derivation above undergoes an instance of $\bar{A}$ -movement to a focus position at the left-periphery of its immediately containing clause. This results in an IP constituent that can be elided to produce the desired surface string.⁷

An analysis along these lines correctly predicts that the remnant will display behaviors that connect it to the elided structure from which it has been extracted. For instance, the remnant, which is proposed to undergo $\bar{A}$ -movement, is expected to be sensitive to island boundaries (e.g., [Reinhart 1991](#), [Wu 2022](#); cf. [Potter 2017](#)). The following pair of examples, which are adapted from [Merchant \(2004\)](#) and [Lechner \(2004\)](#) respectively, demonstrate that the remnant of stripping cannot be interpreted as a constituent within a Complex-NP Island.

⁶I will adopt the convention of enclosing constituents that have been targeted for ellipsis in angled brackets: $\langle XP \rangle$.

⁷[Ott & Struckmeier \(2018\)](#) explicate a concern to be had with regard Move-and-Delete approaches. Specifically, the proposed movement of the remnant can be difficult to independently motivate. Consider (i), which is the full non-elided version of (8). Comparable fronting of *bread* in this case is odd at best.

(i) ?Smith₁ ate seafood yesterday and bread₂ she₁ ate *t*₂ yesterday too.

This speaks to various alternative approaches to stripping that would treat the remnant as an in-situ constituent; see [Chao 1987](#), [McCawley 1991](#) and [Culicover & Jackendoff 2005](#). In light of such concerns, [Johnson \(2019\)](#) proposes that we expand our conception of what types of movements can be employed to generate remnants. This comes hand-in-hand with proposals that stripping may be applied to coordinated constituents of various sizes (see [Lechner 2004](#), [Konietzko 2016](#), [Hirsch 2017](#)). Thus, the movement employed in (i) may not necessarily be the movement employed in the derivation of stripping constructions.

For the purposes of this manuscript, we will treat these issues as orthogonal to those issues consideration. It is worth noting, however, that further investigation into the relationship between sprouting and the size of the elided constituent may be called for; see [Overfelt 2024](#).

- (9) I met [DP the linguist who studies DUTCH] but not
 a. [DP the linguist who studies CATALAN]₁ < ~~I met t₁~~ >
 b. *CATALAN₁ < ~~I met [DP the linguist who studies t₁]~~ >
- (10) I spent time with [DP the person who plays THE CLARINET] but not
 a. [DP the person plays THE LUTE]₁ < ~~I spent time with t₁~~ >
 b. *THE LUTE₁ < ~~I spent time with [DP the person who plays t₁]~~ >

The (a) variants of the examples above demonstrates the grammaticality of a remnant that contains a Complex-NP Island. The ungrammaticality of the (b) variants, therefore, can be understood from the assertion that the attempted remnants have been extracted from the relative clause.⁸

It is possible to make the same argument with appeal to the Left-Branch Condition. The following examples demonstrate that possessors and attributive adjectives cannot serve as the remnant of stripping.

- (11) Alfred read [DP JULIE's book] but not
 a. [DP LEE's book]₁ < ~~Alfred read t₁~~ >
 b. *LEE₁ < ~~Alfred read [DP t₁'s book]~~ >
- (12) Carol will buy [DP a FAST car] but not
 a. [DP a SLOW car]₁ < ~~Carol will buy t₁~~ >
 b. *SLOW₁ < ~~Carol will buy [DP a t₁ car]~~ >

The (a) variants in this case demonstrate the grammaticality of a remnant that contains a left-branch constituent. This allows us to conclude that the ungrammaticality of the (b) variants arises from the attempted extraction of a remnant from the these island environments.

We also make specific predictions regarding the remnant's behavior with respect to binding. If the remnant of stripping is $\bar{A}$ -moved from elided material, it will show binding connectivity effects with that elided material (e.g., [Lechner 2004](#), [Bhatt & Takahashi 2011](#)). Observe first that the string in (13) is ambiguous between the interpretations that are provided. The remnant *his boss* can either receive a subject interpretation (13a) or an indirect object interpretation (13b). As [Rooth](#)

⁸There is a grammatical “short-source” interpretation of (9b) and (10b) on a different bracketing ([Barros et al. 2014](#)). If coordination is at the level of the embedded predicate, the following interpretations emerge:

- (i) I met [DP the linguist who₂ [t₂ studies DUTCH but not CATALAN₁ < t₂ studies t₁ >]]
 (ii) I spent time with [DP the person who₂ [t₂ plays THE CLARINET but not THE LUTE₁ < t₂ plays t₁ >]]

These bracketings would not require extraction of the remnant out of the ellipsis site to avoid deletion and, therefore, would not induce an island violation. Therefore, it is specifically the absence of the interpretations in the text that demonstrate island-sensitivity.

(1992b) discusses with respect to stripping-like constructions more generally, the placement of a pitch accent in the first conjunct corresponds to the interpretation of the remnant *his boss* in the elided content.

- (13) a. MAX sent Joe₁ to Sue but not HIS₁ BOSS₂ $\langle t_2$ sent him₁ to Sue $\rangle$
 “... but his boss didn’t send Joe to Sue.”
 b. Max sent Joe₁ to SUE but not HIS₁ BOSS₂ $\langle$ Max sent him₁ to t_2 $\rangle$
 “... but Max didn’t send him to his boss.”

Knowing this, the pair of sentences in (14), in which the R-expression *Joe* and its coreferent pronoun are switched, are informative.

- (14) a. MAX sent **him**₁ to Sue but not **JOE**₁’S BOSS₂ $\langle t_2$ sent **him**₁ to Sue $\rangle$
 “... but Joe’s boss didn’t send him to Sue.”
 b. *Max sent **him**₁ to SUE but not **JOE**₁’S BOSS₂ $\langle$ Max sent **him**₁ to t_2 $\rangle$
 “... but Max didn’t send him to Joe’s boss.”

Of note is the fact that the ambiguity observed above is missing in (14). The indirect object interpretation in (14b) is intuitively interrupted by a disjoint reference effect. This is precisely what an ellipsis analysis of these constructions predicts. Assuming that the remnant is extracted from some elided material, the indirect object interpretation will require generating the the R-expression *Joe’s boss* in the scope of the coreferent pronouns *him*. The observed ungrammaticality, therefore, is expected as the result of a Condition C violation.

Evidence for ellipsis can also be found in the form of an argument that Ross (1967) originally presented for sluicing. Observe, first, that stripping is capable of targeting the complement clause of non-factive predicates, as in the examples below.⁹

- (15) WHO left? — I think [_{CP} JOHN₁ $\langle t_1$ left $\rangle$]. (Weir 2014a:231, (476))

- (16) Jane loves to study ROCKS and
 John says [_{CP} GEOGRAPHY₁ $\langle$ Jane loves to study t_1 $\rangle$] too.
 (Wurmbrand 2017:344, (5d))

Considering the example in (15) specifically, the relevant observation is that the selectional restrictions of the predicate *think* cannot be satisfied by the remnant alone. That is, *think* does not take

⁹Wurmbrand (2017) discusses and presents an analysis for the observation that stripping in embedded complement clauses is possible only in the absence of a complementizer. Compare (16) in the text with (i) below:

- (i) Jane loves to study ROCKS and
 a. *John says that GEOGRAPHY too.
 b. *John says GEOGRAPHY that too. (adapted from Wurmbrand 2017:344, (5c))

proper names as an argument outside the present context of stripping:¹⁰

(17) *I think John.

However, it is possible to understand the usage of *think* above if, in the way that is illustrated in (15), this predicate combines with a clausal complement that is reduced by ellipsis. The clausal complement, not the proper name, would satisfy the predicate’s subcategorization requirements and grammaticality would be expected.

It is also possible to extend these facts into an argument for ellipsis on the basis of the selectional constraints placed on the remnant (see also Yoshida 2013). The example in (18a) below establishes the observation by Lobeck (1995) that it is possible to extract a PP in order for it to serve as the remnant of a stripping site. The minimally differing example in (18b) helps to demonstrate further that the choice of preposition in the PP remnant cannot be determined by the local predicate *think*.

- (18) Someone already gave the handout to JAN and
- a. I think [**to** RILEY]₁ < ~~someone MAX gave the handout~~ *t*₁ > also.
 - b. *I think [**of** RILEY]₁ < ~~someone already gave the handout~~ *t*₁ > also.

While the predicate *think* does take PP complements, example (19) shows that its lexical-selectional constraints call for PPs headed by the preposition *of*; *think* cannot combine with PPs headed by *to*.

(19) I think { **of** / ***to** } Riley.

The analysis presented in (18a) offers a straightforward way of understanding the observation that, on the intended interpretation, the remnant of stripping is subject to the lexical-selectional requirements of the predicate in the first conjunct. As the complement of an elided instance of the predicate *give*, the remnant will of course need to meet the selectional requirements of this predicate.

In sum, there is evidence that the remnant of stripping configurations is extracted from elided syntactic content. The need to recover an antecedent for this elided content will guide our analysis of the observation, to be introduced in detail in section 4, that stripping is more restricted in certain configurations.

¹⁰Weir (2014a) offers an extended discussion of the distinction between the cases of stripping at hand and quotative uses of such predicates such as: *I think*, “*John*.”

2.2 Comparative stripping

A commonly encountered claim regarding stripping is that it is only possible in coordination configurations or across utterance boundaries. Indeed, there is a tendency for stripping to be prohibited in subordinate clauses like those below (Lobeck 1995).

(20) *JOHN studied rocks even though not JANE ~~studied rocks~~. (Lobeck 1995:27, (70b))

(21) a. *Jones likes SEAFOOD because ~~she likes~~ BREAD too.

b. *Jones eats SEAFOOD whenever ~~she eats~~ BREAD too.

(adapted from Johnson 2019:562, (4a)–(4b))

One relatively well-known case that has been proposed to counter-exemplify this tendency is referred to with the theory-neutral term Comparative Ellipsis.¹¹ In pairs of examples like (22) and (23) below, the idea is that the phrasal comparatives in the (b) variants are derivationally related to the clausal comparatives in the respective (a) variants. The omission of clausal material within the *than*-phrase to the exclusion of a single phrasal standard of comparison is treated as the product of an ellipsis mechanism (e.g., Hankamer 1987, Bresnan 1975, Lechner 2004).

(22) a. Steven meets with ANITA less often [than he meets with FRANK]

b. Steven meets with ANITA less often [than ~~he meets~~ **with FRANK**]

(23) a. CARLA runs faster [than MARK runs]

b. CARLA runs faster [than **MARK runs**]

The need to understand what appears to be ellipsis of a non-constituent again motivates a syntactic analysis for phrasal comparatives, like the one in (24), whereby the phrasal standard is $\overline{A}$ -extracted out of elided material to become a remnant.¹²

¹¹There are several other embedded environments that have been proposed to represent stripping(-like) constructions. These include temporal adverbial clauses (Geis 1970, Larson 1987, Thompson 2005, Overfelt 2021), fragment utterances (Reich 2007, Boone 2014, Weir 2014a), *why*-stripping (Yoshida et al. 2015, Weir 2014b), *like*-clauses (Yoshida 2013), *except*-clauses (Reinhart 1991, Vokstrikova 2021), *if*-clauses (Myers & Yoshida 2019), and *although*-clauses (Park & Kim 2023). While space precludes engaging with all of these on the present occasion, we will return to temporal adverbial clauses in section 6. The hope is that this article will open up a vein of future research into stripping and its associated constructions.

¹²Like canonical stripping, the literature on phrasal comparatives has seen discussion regarding the amount of structure that is elided. For example, Merchant (2009) argues that reduced phrasal comparatives in Greek involve clausal ellipsis. Kennedy & Lidz (2001) and Drummond & Shimoyama (2014) argue that comparative ellipsis in English removes an intermediate constituent between the clausal-level and the predicate. As already noted, Lechner (2004) argues that comparative ellipsis in German reduces both clausal constituents (IPs, AgrSPs, TPs) and sub-clausal constituents (AspPs, VPs). Pancheva (2006) argues that cross-linguistic differences in phrasal comparatives can be understood if phrasal comparatives are generated by eliding either a clausal constituent or the predicate in a small-clause configuration, depending on the language. In the same way as above, we will treat these issues as ultimately being orthogonal to the claims that are made here, though further investigation will be necessary.

- (24) Felix eats SEAFOOD more often [than **BREAD**₁ $\langle$ ~~IP Felix eats t_T~~ $\rangle$]

This type of analysis stands in contrast to those proposing that there is no ellipsis or reduction mechanism at play. Instead, the phrasal standard of comparison is treated as composing directly with a prepositional standard marker *than* (e.g., [Hankamer 1987](#), [Napoli 1983](#), [Heim 1985](#), [Kennedy 1999](#)).¹³

The same arguments that have been put forward for an ellipsis analysis of canonical stripping have been presented in support of the ellipsis approach to phrasal comparatives. For instance, [Reinhart \(1991\)](#) and [Lechner \(2004\)](#) observe that the phrasal standard of comparison is sensitive to island boundaries. The examples below, which are minimally adapted from examples presented in the previous subsection, serve as relevant evidence.

- (25) I visit [DP the linguist who knows DUTCH] more often
 a. [DP the linguist who knows CATALAN]₁ $\langle$ ~~I visit t_T~~ $\rangle$
 b. *CATALAN₁ $\langle$ ~~I visit [DP the linguist who knows t_T]~~ $\rangle$
- (26) I spend time with [DP the person who plays THE CLARINET] less eagerly than
 a. [DP the person plays THE LUTE]₁ $\langle$ ~~I spend time with t_T~~ $\rangle$
 b. *THE LUTE₁ $\langle$ ~~I spend time with [DP the person who plays t_T]~~ $\rangle$

Comparative Ellipsis is similarly sensitive to the Left-Branch Condition, as shown in the following examples:

- (27) Alfred read [DP JULIE's book] more enthusiastically than
 a. [DP LEE's book]₁ $\langle$ ~~Alfred read t_T~~ $\rangle$
 b. *LEE₁ $\langle$ ~~Alfred read [DP t_T 's book]~~ $\rangle$
- (28) Carol will buy [DP a FAST car] more enthusiastically than
 a. [DP a SLOW car]₁ $\langle$ ~~Carol will buy t_T~~ $\rangle$
 b. *SLOW₁ $\langle$ ~~Carol will buy [DP a t_T car]~~ $\rangle$

The grammaticality pattern for these phrasal comparatives is, once again, expected under the assumption that a remnant undergoes $\bar{A}$ -movement to a position where it escapes elided content.

The binding facts presented in the previous subsection were adapted from demonstrations by [Lechner \(2004\)](#) and [Bhatt & Takahashi \(2011\)](#) that a phrasal standard of comparison is connected to elided material. In the same way as above, the ambiguity observed regarding the grammatical role of the phrasal standard in (29) is resolved in (30), where the positions of the R-expression and

¹³Note that there is no intention to claim here that there are no phrasal comparatives that involve direct composition. The reader should see [Lechner \(2019\)](#) for further discussion.

pronoun are exchanged.

- (29) a. MAX sent **Joe**₁ to Sue earlier than **HIS**₁ BOSS₂ $\langle t_2 \text{ sent } \text{him}_1 \text{ to Sue} \rangle$
 “... earlier than his boss sent him to Sue.”
 b. Max sent **Joe**₁ to SUE earlier than **HIS**₁ BOSS₂ $\langle \text{Max sent } \text{him}_1 \text{ to } t_2 \rangle$
 “... earlier than Max sent him to his boss.”
- (30) a. MAX sent **him**₁ to Sue earlier than **JOE**₁’S BOSS₂ $\langle t_2 \text{ sent } \text{him}_1 \text{ to Sue} \rangle$
 “... earlier than Joe’s boss sent him to Sue.”
 b. *Max sent **him**₁ to SUE earlier than **JOE**₁’S BOSS₂ $\langle \text{Max sent } \text{him}_1 \text{ to } t_2 \rangle$
 “... earlier than Max sent him to Joe’s boss.”

The ungrammaticality of the indirect object interpretation for the phrasal standard is again an expected result of a Condition C violation. This interpretation requires a representation in which the phrasal standard, containing an R-expression, is generated in a position that is c-commanded by an instance of a coreferential pronoun and both are elided.¹⁴

Finally, an argument based on the lexical selectional requirement of the remnant, similar to the argument that was offered in section 2.1, can be offered here. The examples in (31) below establish that it is possible for a PP to serve as the remnant of the stripping site and that the choice of preposition is determined by the predicate in the matrix clause.

- (31) Mary interacts with HER CLIENTS more often than
 a. **with** HER EMPLOYEES₁ $\langle \text{Mary interacts } t_1 \rangle$
 b. ***of / for / to** HER EMPLOYEES₁ $\langle \text{Mary interacts } t_1 \rangle$

Despite being a constituent of the comparative adverbial headed by *more often*, the phrasal standard of comparison is subject to the lexical-selectional requirements of the matrix predicate. This can be attributed directly to the fact that it is generated as a complement of an elided instance of the verb *interacts*.¹⁵

¹⁴A potential concern is that (30b) should be independently ruled out as a Condition C violation induced by the R-expression *Joe* being c-commanded by the pronominal in the root clause. This is unlikely to be the source of ungrammaticality, however, as the same effect would presumably be observed in (30a) as well, contrary to fact.

¹⁵Offering an argument exactly like the one provided in section 2.1 to demonstrate that the remnant cannot be selected for by a local embedding predicate is complicated by restrictions against embedded stripping sites within comparative constructions. The reader should consult Lechner 2001, 2004 and Johnson (2019) for discussion. The relevant examples, however, would be as shown in (i).

- (i) We think that Mary interacts with HER CLIENTS more often than
 a. ??we think **with** HER EMPLOYEES $\langle \text{Mary interacts } t_1 \rangle$
 b. *we think **of** HER EMPLOYEES $\langle \text{Mary interacts } t_1 \rangle$

To the extent that either of these examples approaches acceptability, the contrast suggests that the remnant is subject

To summarize again, there is good reason to suspect that at least some phrasal comparatives have syntactic representations in which the phrasal standard is the remnant of an ellipsis mechanism. Moreover, there is good reason to suspect that this mechanism is the same as the one that is responsible for generating remnants in canonical stripping configurations. We have seen that they show the same connectivity signatures and the same structural ambiguities. This, too, will guide our analysis of the contrast between stripping in coordinate structures and comparative clauses to be discovered below.

3 A domain constraint on sprouted stripping

We turn now to the primary empirical phenomenon of interest in this paper: a difference in the availability for sprouted stripping found in coordination and comparative configurations. The discussion in the previous section provided reason to believe that the same ellipsis mechanism is responsible for the derivation of each construction. Granted this conclusion, we should be encouraged to search for an explanation of the differential availability of sprouting that is grounded in some salient difference between these two constructions which can plausibly be held responsible for the licensing of ellipsis. After introducing the primary data to be accounted for, we will consider some possible alternative approaches before moving on to the proposed analysis in the following section.

3.1 Introducing the puzzle

Sprouting has most notably been discussed in research by [Chung, Ladusaw, & McCloskey \(1995, 2011\)](#) and [Chung \(2005\)](#). It is a phenomenon most commonly exemplified by pairs of “sluicing” constructions like in (32).

- (32) a. Kim read **SOMETHING**, but I forgot **WHAT**₁ $\langle$ IP ~~Kim read t_1~~ $\rangle$
 b. Kim read, but I forgot **WHAT**₁ $\langle$ IP ~~Kim read t_1~~ $\rangle$

These examples present the standard analysis of sluicing as an instance ellipsis that targets an IP constituent from which a *wh*-element is extracted. From a descriptive standpoint regarding (32a), the remnant of ellipsis *what* is paired with the “correlate” *something* in the preceding clause. In (32b), the remnant constituent *what* lacks any overt correlate in the preceding clause. It has, therefore, “sprouted” from the ellipsis site.¹⁶

to the lexical-selectional requirements, not of the local predicate *think*, but of an elided instance of *interacts*.

¹⁶The term “sprouting” reflects the theoretical analysis of ellipsis in [Chung et al. 1995](#) as an operation that involves LF-copying. Copying of the antecedent material in (32) would not generate a remnant constituent, thus a remnant sprouts from the ellipsis site.

(33) a. John served dinner **to HIS SISTER** { but not / and probably }
 to HIS FATHER₁ ⟨ ~~John served dinner t_T~~ ⟩.
 b. John served dinner { but not / and probably }
 to HIS FATHER₁ ⟨ ~~John served dinner t_T~~ ⟩
(adapted from Nakao et al. 2012:273, (17b))

(34) a. Kim was reading AN ARTICLE last night { but not / and possibly }
 A NOVEL₁ ⟨ Kim was reading *t*₁ last night ⟩
 b. Kim was reading last night { but not / and possibly }
 A NOVEL₁ ⟨ Kim was reading *t*₁ last night ⟩

(35) a. Felix eats **CHICKEN** { but not / and probably } **SEAFOOD**₁ $\langle \text{Felix eats } t_{\text{F}} \rangle$
b. Felix eats { but not / and probably } **SEAFOOD**₁ $\langle \text{Felix eats } t_{\text{F}} \rangle$

(36) a. Laura can write **at THE OFFICE** { but not / and probably }
AT HOME₁ $\langle \text{Laura can write } t_{\text{L}} \rangle$
b. Laura can write { but not / and probably } **AT HOME** $\langle \text{Laura works } t_{\text{L}} \rangle$

The empirical puzzle of the manuscript is the relative unacceptability of sprouted stripping in comparative constructions. The examples that follow are adapted from those above.

13

- (39) a. Felix (generally) eats **CHICKEN** as fast as **SEAFOOD**₁ $\langle \text{Felix-eats } t_1 \rangle$
b. *Felix (generally) eats as fast as **SEAFOOD**₁ $\langle \text{Felix-eats } t_1 \rangle$
- (40) a. Laura (typically) writes **at THE OFFICE**
for longer than **at HOME**₁ $\langle \text{Laura-writes } t_1 \rangle$
b. *Laura (typically) writes for longer than **at HOME**₁ $\langle \text{Laura-writes } t_1 \rangle$

The (a) variants of these examples provide grammatical controls, demonstrating that stripping is possible in these environments, so long as remnants are paired with overt correlates. Once again, this is possible for a range of categories with different grammatical roles. The (b) variants present the experimental conditions. Their ungrammaticality demonstrates that sprouting is severely degraded, if not outright ungrammatical, in phrasal comparatives.

The analysis to be pursued in the following sections proposes that this failure of sprouting in comparative clauses specifically reflects an inability to recover an antecedent for the elided content. It is important, therefore, to establish that there is nothing in principle that precludes the representations or derivations that underlie the attempted sprouting constructions above. The examples below are provided for this purpose. They have been minimally adapted from the examples above and have been designed to facilitate a salient and plausible interpretation for what are, admittedly, atypical sentences.

- (41) John (normally) served dinner earlier than he served dinner **to his father**.
- (42) Kim was (just now) reading more carefully than she was reading **the novel**.
- (43) Felix (generally) eats as fast as he eats **seafood**.
- (44) Laura (typically) writes for longer than she writes **at home**.

In light of the acceptability of the examples above, the puzzle we are left with is that otherwise attested stripping in comparative clauses becomes ungrammatical when the remnant is sprouted. As noted, we will pursue an analysis that appeals to the ability to accommodate and recover a suitable antecedent for these instances of ellipsis.

3.2 Some non-accommodation approaches

Before introducing the proposed analysis for the puzzle introduced above, we turn to a consideration of some imaginable alternatives that would not rely on antecedent accommodation. It will be argued that in each case we are left wanting for an account that predicts the relevant contrast between canonical stripping and comparative stripping.

3.2.1 Positional constraints on sprouting

A straightforward method of handling the facts at hand would be to state a restriction on sprouting that directly references the domain in which it is being attempted, namely comparative clauses. Similar constraints, which make reference particular syntactic positions or grammatical roles, have been offered and discussed previously in [Chung et al. 1995, 2011](#), [Chung 2005, 2013](#), and [Larson 2014](#). These include the complement position of prepositions (45), the indirect object of double-object constructions (46), and external argument positions (47). Sprouting from these positions results in ungrammaticality.

(45) Molly is speaking **(to someone)*, but I won't say **who**₁ $\langle$ IP ~~Molly is speaking to~~ *t*_T $\rangle$

(46) Ronnie sent **(someone)* a letter, but I don't know **who**₁ $\langle$ IP ~~Ronnie sent~~ *t*_T a letter $\rangle$

(47) **(Someone)* being late is inevitable, but I can't guess **who**₁ $\langle$ IP ~~*t*_T will be late~~ $\rangle$

Regardless of how it is formulated, any constraint on stripping that would make reference to the syntactic position or grammatical role of the remnant would fail to distinguish relevant pairs of examples like those repeated below:

(48) a. Kim was reading (THE ARTICLE) but not THE NOVEL₁ $\langle$ ~~Kim was reading~~ *t*_T $\rangle$

b. Kim was reading **(THE ARTICLE)* more carefully than

THE NOVEL₁ $\langle$ ~~Kim was reading~~ *t*_T $\rangle$

In the above example, the factors of syntactic position and grammatical role are held consonant; the remnant *the novel* is extracted from parallel positions. The minimal difference between the members in each pair is the domain in which sprouting occurs. This suggests we need an analysis that is sensitive to some difference between conjuncts and comparative clauses.

In this vein, one could simply assert the existence of a rule that blocks sprouting specifically in comparative clauses. Looking ahead to the discussion in section 6, this rule might generally ban sprouting from non-complement embedded clauses. It would remain to be explained, however, why such a rule exists. The analysis to be presented, therefore, attempts to derive these observations from more general principles required for the licensing of ellipsis, namely recoverability and accommodation.

3.2.2 Focus Parallelism

An often noted property of ellipsis configurations is a requirement to recover an antecedent constituent that has a focus structure that is parallel to a constituent containing the ellipsis site (e.g., [Rooth 1992a,b](#), [Tancredi 1992](#)). An explicit version of this requirement is formulated by [Winkler](#)

(52) *Scope Parallelism*

An elided constituent E and its antecedent A must be isomorphic with respect to variable binding configurations.

In different words, this constraint requires that a variable-binding relationship in an ellipsis site is matched by a structurally identical variable-binding relationship in the antecedent.

Among the facts that can be seen as falling under the purview of Scope Parallelism is the ungrammaticality of the instance of sprouted sluicing, with the intended meaning shown in (53).

- (53) *I know that few kids ate, but I don't know **what**_I $\langle$ IP ~~few kids ate~~ x _T $\rangle$
"I know that for few kids x , x ate, but I don't know, for what thing y , few kids ate y ."
(Romero 1998:208, (40))

As Romero (1998:61–65) discusses, implicit arguments of the kind found in the first conjunct take narrowest scope relative to other operators and quantificational elements. Thus, the example in (54) below has only a meaning in which *few kids* is interpreted as if it has scope above the existential implicit argument, represented as $pro_{\exists}$.

- (54) I know that few kids ate $pro_{\exists}$.
a. $few > pro_{\exists}$: 'I know that, for few kids x , there is something that x ate.'
b. $*pro_{\exists} > few$: 'I know that there is something y such that few kids ate y .'

Conversely, the constituent question in (56) permits only a single-answer interpretation in which the *wh*-constituent takes widest scope.

- (55) What did few kids eat?
a. $*few > what$: 'For few kids x , what thing did x ate.'
b. $what > few$: 'Which thing y is such that few kids ate y .'

The purported problem with the sprouted sluicing configuration in (53), then, is that the ellipsis site and the antecedent necessarily have non-parallel scopal relations. While the remnant *what* takes widest scope ($what > few$), its correlate, the existential implicit argument, takes narrow scope relative to *few kids* ($few > pro_{\exists}$). This violation of Scope Parallelism has the ultimate effect of precluding the licensing of ellipsis.¹⁹

If we wish to rule out sprouting in the comparative configuration in (56b) below as a violation of Scope Parallelism, we are committed to the claim that there are non-parallel scope relations in

¹⁹For Romero (1998), Scope Parallelism is a product of a focus-based redundancy condition on ellipsis (Rooth 1992a,b). The approach to be presented below relies on the same technology but, as will be shown, necessarily differs with respect to what kinds of discourse objects can serve as a possible antecedent and how they are recovered.

(56) a. Kim was reading *pro*_∃ but not **THE NOVEL**₁ $\langle$ ~~Kim was reading~~ *t*_↑ $\rangle$
 b. *Kim was reading *pro*_∃ more carefully than **THE NOVEL**₁ $\langle$ ~~Kim was reading~~ *t*_↑ $\rangle$

There is an alternative execution of this idea that pivots on a difference between conjuncts and comparative clauses. One might make reference to the additional degree operator-variable relationship commonly believed to be found in clausal comparatives (see [Kennedy 2005](#) and [Lechner & Corver 2017](#) for discussion). Assuming that no isomorphic dependency exists in the second conjunct of canonical stripping configurations, one might assert that Scope Parallelism is satisfied in (57a) but that it is violated by the additional degree operator-variable chain in (57b).

- However, a rich literature has emerged that treats comparatives—and the degree phrase in particular—as quantificational expressions that undergo Quantifier Raising (e.g., [Guéron & May 1984](#), [Heim 2000](#), [Lechner 2004](#), [Bhatt & Pancheva 2004](#)). This means that, on at least some analyses, the Degree Phrase containing the comparative morpheme moves to its scope-taking position, generating a degree operator-variable chain in the matrix clause. On this type of analysis, the example in (58) would provide a more accurate representation of sprouted stripping in a comparative clause:

- In this representation, the degree operator-variable relationship in the ellipsis site finds an isomorphic dependency in the antecedent clause. It is not clear, therefore, that the lack of sprouting in comparatives can be blamed on these scopal relations. Nor is it clear that we should want to place the blame here for the risk of ruling out non-sprouted stripping in comparatives:

(59) Kim was reading **THE ARTICLE** more carefully than **THE NOVEL**.

The grammaticality of these examples requires that the degree operator-variable relationships in the ellipsis site and the antecedent satisfy Scope Parallelism. Therefore, this approach either predicts that sprouting should be ungrammatical in both coordination structures and comparatives or it fails to distinguish sprouted stripping from non-sprouted stripping in comparatives.

4 QUD At-Issue-ness

The previous section introduced the empirical puzzle of the manuscript and argued that several imaginable approaches to this puzzle do not offer an account of the contrasting acceptability of sprouted stripping in canonical coordination structures and comparative structures. This section, therefore, presents an approach that specifically capitalizes on a pertinent difference between the two types of structures, namely their ability to be anaphoric to an accommodated antecedent.

The idea is that suitable antecedents for sprouting constructions are necessarily absent from the immediate discourse and must be accommodated. Sprouting, therefore, is ungrammatical in precisely those domains that cannot be anaphoric to an accommodated antecedent for ellipsis. This idea is executed within a framework developed in [Büring 2003](#) and especially [Roberts 2012](#), where discourses are structured on the basis of questions to be resolved and utterances intended to resolve them. The question that interlocutors are actively attempting to resolve is referred to as the Question Under Discussion (QUD). Following the research cited, the QUD is to be understood as a salient linguistic entity in the discourse that has, at minimum, the logico-semantic content of a question.

The real force of the analysis comes from the concept of At-Issue-ness, which [Simons et al. \(2010\)](#) and [Tonhauser \(2012\)](#) formulate relative to the QUD. This notion provides a way of understanding the intuition that not all utterances, or parts of utterances, are able to felicitously contribute to the task of resolving the QUD. We will adopt the concise definition of QUD At-Issue-ness that is presented by [Koev \(2018:3, \(2\)\)](#):

(60) *QUD At-Issue-ness*

A proposition *p* is At-Issue with respect to the QUD *iff*

- i. *p* is relevant to the QUD and
- ii. *p* is appropriately conventionally marked relative to the QUD.

It is with respect to this concept of QUD At-Issue-ness that we will distinguish coordination structures from comparative structures. It will be found that the content of conjuncts, but not comparative clauses, can be At-Issue with respect to the QUD. This will ultimately determine whether a

QUD can be accommodated as an antecedent for the purpose of licensing sprouted stripping in that domain. The desired result is that this will not be possible for the content of a second conjunct, but not the content of a comparative clause.

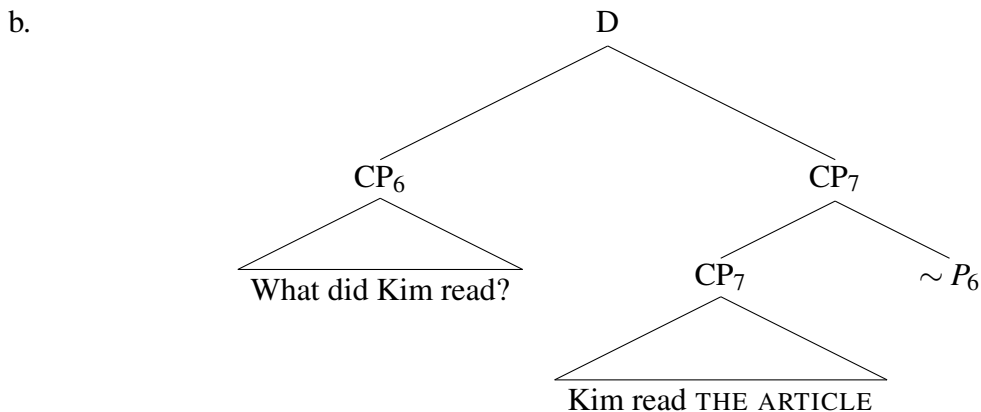
Later sections will demonstrate the technical details of the analysis before demonstrating how we derive the relevant contrast. We will then extend this analysis to two other domains that similarly disallow sprouted stripping and are amenable to the same treatment. Toward these ends, it will be useful to first introduce each clause in the definition of QUD At-Issue-ness in turn.

4.1 Relevance to the QUD

Concerning the first clause of (60), a common way of talking about the relevance of a proposition p to the QUD is whether or not p shifts the probabilistic weights among the possible answers to the question being addressed (Carnap 1950, Büring 2003, Koev 2018). While there are various ways in which this can be achieved, one way to do this, which will be of particular importance here, is through “congruent answers.” These are those answers to the question that, following Rooth (1985, 1992b) and Roberts (2012), have the same focal structure as the question.

By way of demonstration, consider the congruent question-answer pair presented in (61a). This exchange is illustrated by the discourse representation tree in (61b). In this discourse, there is an explicitly proffered question, which is represented as CP_6 and establishes the QUD. The constituent CP_7 represents a congruent answer to the question.

- (61) a. Q: What did Kim read?
A: Kim read the THE ARTICLE.



Congruence based on the focal structure of an utterance is couched within the framework of Alternative Semantics (Rooth 1985, 1992b). Within this framework expressions have both an ordinary semantic value $\llbracket \cdot \rrbracket^o$ and a focus semantic value $\llbracket \cdot \rrbracket^f$. The focus semantic value of an expression is calculated point-wise, like the ordinary semantic value, while also replacing focus-

marked constituents with their alternatives. The result is a set of alternative meanings that exist alongside the ordinary meaning of the utterance.

The focus semantic value of the answer in (61)—offered in the form of CP_7 —is derived by replacing the focus-marked instance of *the article* with its contextually-restricted alternatives and computing the resulting meanings. This delivers the set of propositions shown in (62b).²⁰

- (62) a. $\llbracket CP_7 \rrbracket^f = \llbracket [\text{Kim read THE ARTICLE}] \rrbracket^f$
 b. $\llbracket CP_7 \rrbracket^f = \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{that Kim read the article, that Kim read the novel} \\ \text{that Kim read the magazine, that Kim read the comic, ...} \end{array} \right\}$
 c. $\llbracket CP_7 \rrbracket^f = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim read } x \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the article}) \}$

This set of alternative propositions representing the focus semantic value of CP_7 can be equivalently represented with the set abstraction notation in (62c). The result is a set of propositions with the meaning that Kim read x where x is or is a salient alternative to *the article*.

The interpretation of focus in this way is carried out by $\sim$ (“squiggle”), the focus interpretation operator. The level at which focus is interpreted is determined by the point of adjunction of $\sim$ to some constituent XP. This is in turn informed by the presupposition, triggered by $\sim$, that some element can be recovered from the discourse that meets one of the two conditions of the Focus Interpretation Principle:

- (63) *Focus Interpretation Principle* (adapted from Rooth 1992a:86, (27))

In interpreting focus at the level of a phrase XP:

- i.) there must be some Γ such that $\llbracket \Gamma \rrbracket^o \subseteq \llbracket XP \rrbracket^f$ or
 ii.) there must be some γ such that $\llbracket \gamma \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket XP \rrbracket^f$

Stated differently, it must possible to recover some discourse element whose ordinary semantic value is either (i) a set of elements that is a subset of the focus semantic value of the constituent XP or (ii) a member of the focus semantic value of XP.²¹

Recovery of a discourse element for evaluation relative to (63) is achieved via indexing with a variable P_n , which is introduced as an argument of $\sim$ and whose semantic type is determined by the phrase to which $\sim$ is adjoined. Still considering the discourse in (61), adjunction of $\sim$ to CP_7 comes with a variable ranging over sets of propositions. Following Hamblin (1973), Rooth (1992a) and

²⁰The notation adopted below for expository purposes obscures the fact that propositions would be more precisely conceived of as sets of functions from worlds to truth values. Other researchers have found explanatory power in treating alternatives, or the QUD specifically, as a set of structured propositions or structured LF representations (Thoms 2015, Weir 2018, Griffiths 2019b).

²¹Rooth (1992a) also adds to the presupposed conditions on interpreting focus that there are requirements for distinctness between the recovered discourse element and the constituent XP containing focus marking. While I will abstract away from this issue here, the reader might consult Repp (2016) and Stockwell (2020) for recent discussions of the relevance of such a requirement.

Kotek (2019), the ordinary semantic value of the question represented by CP_6 can be modeled as just such an object: a set of propositions composed of possible answers to that question. Assuming that *wh*-constituents like *what* vary as part of the calculation of the set of possible answers, the meaning of CP_6 will be as represented in (64b). This can again be equivalently represented with the set abstraction notation in (64c).

- (64) a. $\llbracket CP_6 \rrbracket^o = \llbracket [\text{WHAT did Kim read}] \rrbracket^o$
 b. $\llbracket CP_6 \rrbracket^o = \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{that Kim read the article, that Kim read the novel} \\ \text{that Kim read the magazine, that Kim read the comic, ...} \end{array} \right\}$
 c. $\llbracket CP_6 \rrbracket^o = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim read } x \mid x \in Alt(\text{what}) \}$

Thus, it is via co-indexing that P_6 in the discourse tree in (61) recovers the explicitly proffered QUD in CP_6 as its discourse antecedent. As shown in (65), this is validated by satisfaction of clause (i) of the Focus Interpretation Principle.

- (65) a. $\llbracket CP_6 \rrbracket^o = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim read } x \mid x \in Alt(\text{what}) \}$
 b. $\llbracket CP_7 \rrbracket^f = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim read } x \mid x \in Alt(\text{the article}) \}$
 c. $\llbracket CP_6 \rrbracket^o \subseteq \llbracket CP_7 \rrbracket^f$

The constituent CP_7 in (61), therefore, is congruent to the QUD in that same example. As such, it is relevant to the QUD as a possible answer.

4.2 Conventional marking relative to the QUD

The second clause of the definition for QUD At-Issue in (60) says, in the words of Koev (2018), that p must be “appropriately packaged” in a linguistic form that both sufficiently signals and permits relevance to the QUD. It is on this dimension that I propose we find the operative difference between the content of second conjuncts and the content of comparative clauses. More specifically, there is evidence to suggest that the content of a second conjunct is packaged in such a way that it can be construed as an intent to address the QUD. In this sense, it is content that is QUD At-Issue. This is similar to the discussions presented by Bach (1999) and Potts (2005), who argue that *but* conjoins two separate at-issue propositions. The content of comparatives, on the other hand, will be found to behave as if it is not packaged in such a way that signals an intent to address the QUD. On this measure, the content contained inside these configurations is, therefore, QUD Not-At-Issue.

Before proceeding with the discussion it is worth clarifying the intended claim. There is no intention to assert that comparatives cannot be or be a part of QUD At-Issue content. With the discussion to follow in hand, it will be possible to demonstrate that comparative expressions as a whole can be interpreted as At-Issue content. The claim to be had in the forthcoming discussion is

specifically that the propositional content contained within a comparative *than*-clause is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD.

To illustrate, consider the comparative construction in the example below:

- (66) Kim was working on her article
more/less carefully than [she was reading the novel *d-carefully*]

The comparative clause has as part of its content a proposition expressing that Kim was reading the novel with a degree *d* of carefulness, which, of course, entails the proposition that Kim was reading the novel. It is this content specifically that we will see is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD. Again, this distinguishes the content of a comparative clause from the content of a second conjunct in examples like (67):

- (67) a. Kim wasn't reading the article but [she was reading the novel]
b. Sam made breakfast and [he cleaned the counter]

The material in the second conjunct following *but* in (67a) expresses similar propositional content—that Kim was reading the novel. However, we will find that, packaged in this way, it manages to serve as QUD At-Issue content. The same goes for the content of the second conjunct following *and* in (67b).

Evidence that speaks to this distinction can be found in a set of diagnostic tests proposed and consolidated by Tonhauser (2012). The purpose of these diagnostics is to assess whether some proposition is appropriately packaged in a way that permits its relevance to the QUD. One such diagnostic is based on the hypothesis that, if some propositional content can be construed as QUD At-Issue, it can be directly assented to. The prediction, therefore, is that expressing acceptance of content that is Not-At-Issue will be infelicitous. The examples in (68) test this prediction by having speaker B assent to speaker A's statement with two separate strategies.

- (68) A: Kim was working on her article more/less carefully than she was reading the novel.
B1: #Yes, true, she was reading the novel (carefully).
B2: Yes, true, she was working on her article more/less carefully.

In the response from B1, the follow-up utterance explicitly reinforces that it is the content of the comparative clause to which B1 is assenting. Specifically, B1 is assenting to the proposition that Kim was reading the novel, and possibly to the proposition that she did so with some amount of care. As indicated, this does not represent an acceptable response. The assent in B2 is followed by an utterance clarifying that the assent is to the content of the matrix clause. Intuitively, this is a felicitous discourse strategy. The contrast demonstrates, as suggested, that the content of a comparative clause is Not-At-Issue.

The same diagnostic can be applied to relevant coordination configurations, as shown below in (69) and (70). The response from B1 in each case offers an assent to speaker A's statement and a continuation that clarifies consent to the second of the two conjuncts. The response by B2 also offers assent but it comes with a continuation that conveys assent to the first conjunct.

(69) A: Kim wasn't working on her article but she was reading the novel.

B1: Yes, true, she was reading the novel.

B2: Yes, true, she wasn't working on her article.

(70) A: Sam made breakfast and he cleaned the counter.

B1: Yes, true, he did clean the counter.

B2: Yes, true, he did make breakfast.

Focusing first on (69), the response from B1 is relatively acceptable in the context, particularly when compared to the experiment with a comparative clause in (68). As noted, this ability to explicitly consent to the material in the second conjunct is consistent with the claim that this proposition is At-Issue content. The response from B2, is similarly relatively acceptable, revealing that the first conjunct is also At-Issue content.

Turning to (70), while I and several consultants perceive the responses from B to again be relatively acceptable in comparison to (68), they are arguably less natural than one might expect, given the claims. I would suggest that this is a reflection of a contradictory Scalar Implicature associated with the coordinating conjunction *and* that arises from B's continuation. That is, B's assent to just one conjunct *P* of A's assertion that *[P and Q]* conversationally implicates *[not (P and Q)]*. After all, if B knew that *[P and Q]* were true, they would have said so. The perception of infelicity, therefore, reflects the calculation of an implicature from participant B that contradicts participant A. However, as a conversational implicature, it can be cancelled: *Yes, true, he did clean the counter and he also made breakfast*. The result is a continuation that is relatively acceptable.

The complication noted above makes it appropriate to examine a second diagnostic. A particularly relevant test for the purposes of the analysis is based on the hypothesis that some propositional content can solely serve as an answer to the QUD only if it is At-Issue content. The example below presents an attempt to answer the QUD solely with the content of a comparative clause.

(71) A: What was Kim reading carefully?

B1: #Kim is working on her article

more/less carefully than she was reading THE NOVEL.

The explicitly proffered QUD in the example above will serve as the discourse antecedent for congruent answers that have the form of a proposition in the set below:

(72) $\{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \text{ } d\text{-carefully} \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{what}) \}$

As has been noted, a comparative clause, like the one in the response from B1 in (71), has as part of its content a proposition of the appropriate form. This content, therefore, is relevant to the QUD in the way defined above in section 4.1. Nonetheless, it cannot felicitously be construed as the answer to speaker A's question. On the basis of this diagnostic too, the content of a comparative clause is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD.

As noted, the claim here is not that the comparative clause as a whole cannot be construed as QUD-At-Issue content. After all, a comparative construction naturally serves as the answer to a question like the following:

- (73) a. How carefully was Kim reading the article?
b. Kim was reading the article more/less carefully than she was reading the novel.

Thus, a comparative construction in its entirety can be construed as QUD At-Issue content. The claim to be had here, again, is that it is the propositional content of the comparative *than*-clause that is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD.

This stands in contrast to a congruent answer that is packaged within a second conjunct, as shown in the example below:

- (74) A: What was Kim reading?
B: Kim is working on her article but she was reading THE NOVEL.
- (75) A: What did Sam clean?
B: Sam made breakfast and he cleaned THE COUNTER.

The questions from speaker A here will find congruent answers in the shape of propositions that are members of one of the following sets:

(76) $\{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{what}) \}$

(77) $\{ p : p = \text{that Sam cleaned } x \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{what}) \}$

The content of the second conjuncts of (74) and (75) offer a proposition of the appropriate form, making them the sole content that is relevant to their respective QUDs. With the understanding that the responses from speaker B also serve to signal the pursuit of more complex discourse strategies than what is explicitly presented, this content felicitously provides the answer to speaker A's questions. In line with previous research, then, the relative acceptability of these responses suggests that the content of a second conjunct is At-Issue with respect to the QUD.

In sum, the contrasts presented in the data above support the claim that the content of second

conjuncts and the content of comparatives have a different status in the discourse. With respect to the concept of QUD At-Issue, content that is intended to be relevant to the QUD can be packaged inside of a second conjunct, but not inside the *than*-clause of a comparative construction. In conjunction with the data examined in section 3.1, we can appreciate that this distinction coincides with the possibility for sprouted stripping. Specifically, sprouted stripping is not possible in QUD Not-At-Issue content. The following section turns to an account for this correlation.

5 Sprouting is gated by QUD At-Issue

The following discussion aims to make the possibility for sprouting a function of the ability to accommodate and recover a QUD antecedent for ellipsis. This will ultimately be determined by the At-Issue status of content targeted by ellipsis. Before looking at the analysis in detail, we will first introduce the relevant mechanisms for antecedent recovery.

5.1 Antecedent recovery for ellipsis

Along with a Recoverability condition, it was mentioned that ellipsis is also subject to a condition requiring that there be some level of identity with an antecedent. For Rooth (1992a), this is a requirement that can be enforced by appealing to the same constraint on the interpretation of focus that was introduced above. More specifically, the condition for semantic redundancy built into the Focus Interpretation Principle is argued to be capable (at least in part) of enforcing the relevant kind of identity that is required in the licensing of ellipsis.

We will adopt the Ellipsis Redundancy Condition offered below to serve this purpose.²²

(78) *Ellipsis Redundancy Condition*

Ellipsis of XP is permitted only if:

- i. there is a recoverable antecedent constituent (AC),
- ii. there is a Parallelism Domain (PD) that contains XP, and
- iii. either $\llbracket AC \rrbracket^o \subseteq \llbracket PD \rrbracket^f$ or $\llbracket AC \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket PD \rrbracket^f$.

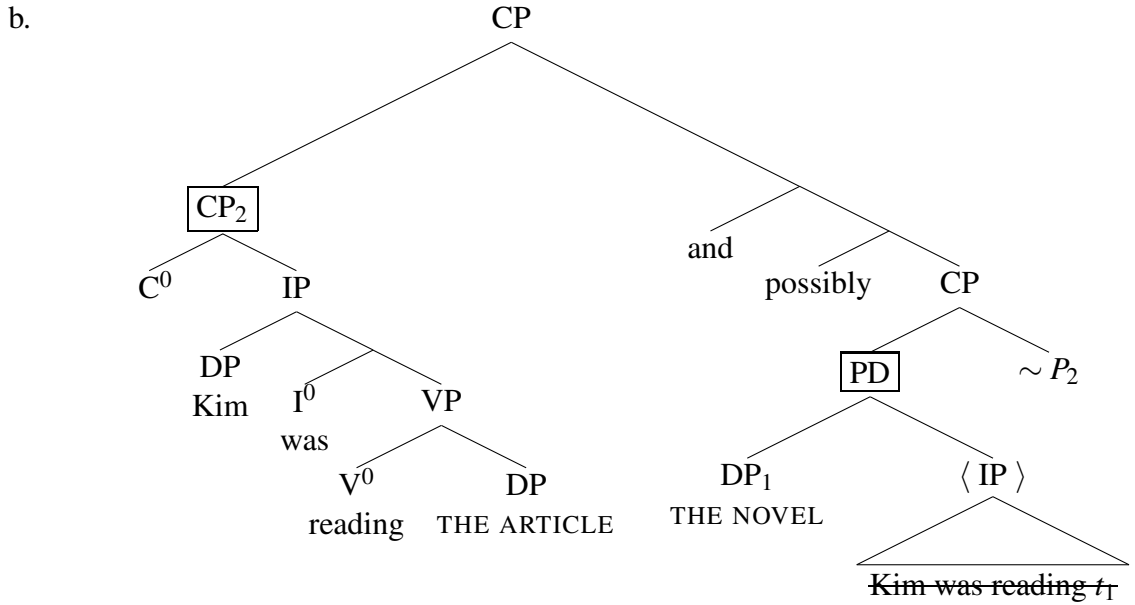
Stated plainly, this condition requires that an elided constituent be contained within some constituent referred to as a Parallelism Domain. It is this constituent for which an appropriate antecedent must be recovered from the discourse. The appropriateness of an antecedent constituent for establishing redundancy is determined by the principles of focus interpretation. Namely, the ordinary semantic value of the antecedent must be a subset or a member of the focus semantic value of the PD. This semantic redundancy, established as part of interpreting focus-marked elements,

²²The constraint presented in (78) is modeled on the discussion found in Takahashi & Fox (2005).

licenses reduction of the redundant material by way of ellipsis.

As an extension of Rooth’s (1992a) Alternative Semantics theory of focus interpretation, we can similarly understand the condition in (78) to be enforced by the focus interpretation operator $\sim$. As a point of illustration, the example (79b) below presents the representation for stripping in a coordination structure. Informed by the results of section 2, the remnant constituent *the novel* is $\bar{A}$ -moved to a position in the left periphery of its containing clause where it is spared an application of ellipsis targeting the IP.

(79) a. Kim was reading THE ARTICLE and possibly THE NOVEL.



In the same way as above, the level at which focus is interpreted is determined by the point of adjunction of $\sim$. This in turn determines the PD, the constituent for which an appropriate antecedent must be recovered. In this case, adjunction of $\sim$ to the CP constituent dominating the remnant will permit both focus-marking on the remnant to be validated and a suitable antecedent to be recovered from the discourse. The indexing P_2 on the variable argument of $\sim$ represents recovery of the first conjunct CP_2 as the antecedent for ellipsis.²³

With this in hand, let us consider the calculation of redundancy for the purpose of ellipsis-licensing, which is presented in (80):

²³The presence of focus in the initial conjunct means that focus interpretation will take place there as well. As Rooth (1992b) notes, this is part of the idea that the two constituents are being placed in opposition, or in contrast. As has been noted previously, this is thought to be a crucial part of both interpreting focus and licensing ellipsis. I will abstract away from this issue for the purpose of the present manuscript. However, the reader should see Griffiths (2019a) and Stockwell (2020) for extended discussion of the relevance that such requirement has specifically for ellipsis licensing.

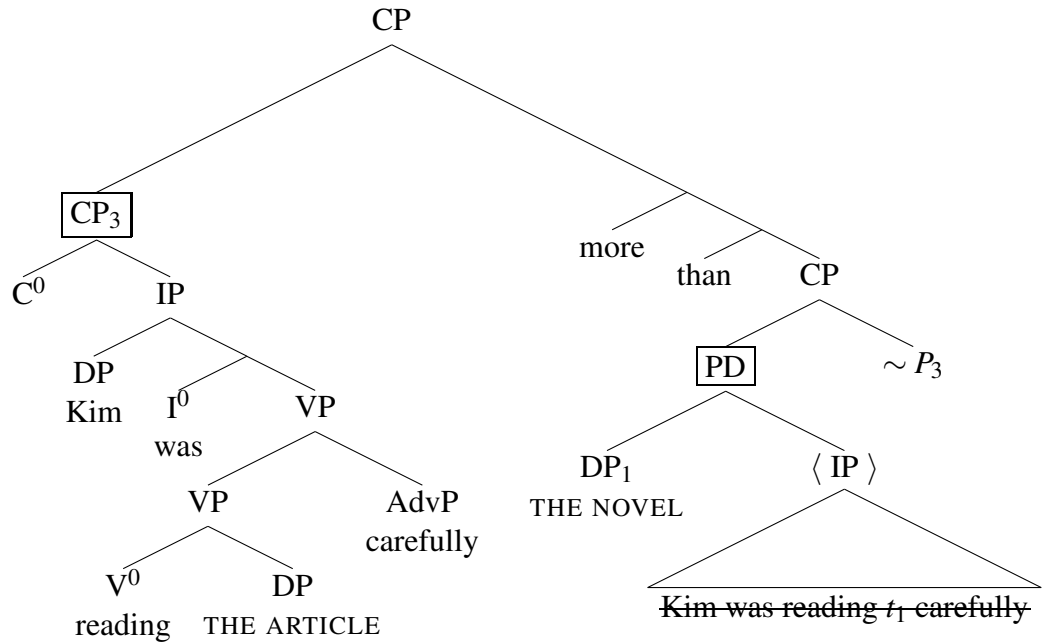
- (80) i. $\llbracket \text{CP}_2 \rrbracket^o = \text{that Kim was reading the article}$
 ii. $\llbracket \text{PD} \rrbracket^f = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the novel}) \}$
 iii. $\llbracket \text{CP}_2 \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket \text{PD} \rrbracket^f$, ellipsis is permitted

As shown in (81a), the ordinary semantic value of CP_2 , the constituent recovered as the antecedent, is a proposition with the meaning that Kim was reading the article. The focus semantic value of the Parallelism Domain is calculated by replacing the focus-marked remnant *the novel* with its salient alternatives. This yields a set of propositions that have the form in (80ii). Because the ordinary semantic value of CP_2 is a member of the focus semantic value of the PD, ellipsis of the IP contained inside the PD is permitted.

This in fact mirrors precisely the treatment for stripping in reduced clausal comparatives that is offered in Rooth (1992b:sec.8). For the purpose of illustration, let us assume the possibly naïve representation show in (81).²⁴

- (81) a. Kim was reading THE ARTICLE more carefully than THE NOVEL.

b.



In the case at hand the constituent CP_3 is recovered as the antecedent for ellipsis via an anaphoric link with the variable P_3 . The ordinary semantic value of this phrase is the proposition in (82i) below. The focus semantic value of the Parallelism Domain is the set of propositions in (82ii).

²⁴See Bhatt & Pancheva (2004) and Lechner & Corver (2017) on the constituency of comparative constructions. This representation also abstracts away from the issues associated with the binding/rebinding of the degree variables in the matrix and comparative clauses. Doing so allows for a cleaner presentation of the analysis without necessarily affecting the claims being made. See the discussion in section 3.2.3.

- (82) i. $\llbracket \text{CP}_3 \rrbracket^o = \text{that Kim was reading the article } d\text{-carefully}$
 ii. $\llbracket \text{PD} \rrbracket^f = \{ p : \text{that Kim was reading } x \text{ } d\text{-carefully} \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the novel}) \}$
 iii. $\llbracket \text{CP}_3 \rrbracket^o \in \llbracket \text{FD} \rrbracket^f$, ellipsis is permitted

Because the ordinary semantic value of CP_3 is a member of the set denoted by the focus semantic value of the Parallelism Domain, redundancy is established and ellipsis within the comparative clause is licensed.

5.2 Sprouted stripping recovers the QUD

With the necessary technology in place, we turn now to the issue of sprouting in examples like (83):

- (83) Kim was reading and probably THE NOVEL.

In the analysis to come, I will propose, following other researchers, that sprouting requires accommodation of an antecedent. This will be argued to be a necessary consequence of the first conjunct *Kim was reading* in (83) not providing a suitable antecedent for licensing ellipsis in the second conjunct. In this way, the proposal to come differs from previous work by Fortin (2007, 2011), Barros (2014) and Barros & Kotek (2019). While these researchers maintain that implicit arguments and adjuncts in the first conjunct contribute to a well-formed antecedent for sprouting, I will argue that they do not.

I will propose instead that, at least in the case of stripping, sprouting requires the accommodation of a QUD to serve as the antecedent for licensing ellipsis. This QUD is drawn from a set of questions that are conversationally implicated by the material in the first conjunct and is “selected” on the basis of the sprouted remnant. As such, the analysis to come is reminiscent of the treatment for sprouting in the context of sluicing by AnderBois (2011, 2014) and fragment answers by Weir (2014a). These researchers also propose that ellipsis is licensed by the accommodation of a QUD (or inquisitive content) in the context of a sprouted remnant. This, too, distinguishes the present analysis from the proposals in Fox 2000, Barros 2014, Barros & Kotek 2019 and Stockwell 2024. In those works, the antecedent for sprouting is accommodated on the basis of the entailments of preceding spoken material or the presuppositions triggered by the ellipsis-containing clause. As we will see below, it is not clear that these can be the relevant factors for antecedent accommodation in the cases at hand.

What the analysis to come has in common with all of the literature cited above is that the remnant of ellipsis is instrumental in directing the accommodation process. However, the specific implementation of this idea differs in important ways from some of the other previous literature on antecedent accommodation (Fox 1999, 2000, Johnson 2012, van Craenenbroeck 2013, Thoms

2015). Notably, the proposed accommodation seeking material—the remnant of stripping—is focus-marked content. Thus, accommodation is being required for non-given material in the discourse. Moreover, the accommodated QUD antecedent involves the addition of a correlate for the sprouted remnant, which is by definition absent from any spoken content in the preceding discourse. Thus, we are accommodating in the discourse material that is structurally more complex than anything that is explicitly provided. To the extent that the analysis to be proposed is viable and cannot supplant previous analyses, it might require that different accommodation strategies are subject to different constraints.

The analysis below is also presented in context of a body of literature that converges on the idea that different types of ellipsis may recover their antecedents from different domains. For instance, [AnderBois \(2011, 2014\)](#), [Barros \(2014\)](#), [Weir \(2014a\)](#), [Griffiths \(2019b\)](#) have provided extensive argumentation that sluicing or fragment answers require antecedence by a possibly implicit question meaning in the discourse—the QUD in our terms. Each of these authors independently reaches the conclusion that, at minimum, this is not a requirement for VP-Ellipsis, which can recover its antecedent from elsewhere (see also [Overfelt 2024](#); but cf. [Kehler 2015](#), [Barros & Kotek 2019](#)).

This ability to recover different types of antecedents for licensing ellipsis is exactly what one should expect from a licensing condition like the one introduced above in (78). As a system built on Rooth’s (1992a) theory of focus interpretation, an antecedent for ellipsis should in principle be recoverable from anything to which $\sim P$ can be anaphoric. This includes overt syntactic content as well as (possibly implicit) question meanings in the discourse. I will propose in what follows that ellipsis licensing exercises precisely this flexibility in the recovery of an antecedent for stripping. While in the previous subsection redundancy was established via an anaphoric link with a constituent in the previously spoken content, redundancy may also be established with a possibly implicit QUD. Moreover, I will propose that the latter is necessary in cases of sprouted stripping and that this provides a means to account the absence of sprouting in comparatives.

5.2.1 Accommodating QUD antecedents for sprouting

Example (84) presents an abbreviated representation for stripping in a coordination configuration that is based on the structure presented in (79). I propose that this representation, in which the antecedent for the elided material is recovered from the content of the first conjunct, is not a possible representation for this string.

- (84) * $[_{CP} \text{ Kim was reading }]_2 \text{ and probably } [_{PD} \text{ THE NOVEL } \text{Kim was reading } t_1] \sim P_2]$
- i. $[_{CP_2}]^o = \text{that Kim was reading}$
 - ii. $[_{PD}]^f = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the novel}) \}$
 - iii. $[_{CP_2}]^o \notin [_{PD}]^f$, ellipsis is *not* permitted.

The issue with this representation, demonstrated by the calculation of ellipsis redundancy, is that the spoken content in the first conjunct of (84) fails to provide a suitable antecedent for the ellipsis site. The focus semantic value of the parallelism domain containing both the remnant and the ellipsis site is a set of propositions derived by replacing *the novel* with its alternatives. The ordinary semantic value of the first conjunct, I argue, can be neither a member nor a subset of this set.

By hypothesis, the failure to license ellipsis in this way will obtain regardless of one's assumptions regarding the syntactico-semantic realization of implicit arguments (see [Martí 2006](#), [Landau 2010](#), [Barros 2014](#), [Bhatt & Pancheva 2017](#)). Similar to the discussion regarding implicit arguments in section 3.2.3, if the implicit argument in the first conjunct of (84) contributed to the antecedent for stripping, in any form, the same would presumably be true for those cases of sprouted stripping in comparatives, contrary to apparent facts. Therefore, assuming that the an implicit argument plays a role in establishing redundancy in (84) does not obviously lead to an account of the puzzle at hand.

In addition to this consideration, there are other instances identified in the literature where implicit arguments apparently do not contribute to an appropriate antecedent for ellipsis. For example, [Overfelt \(2024\)](#) argues that VP-ellipsis does not permit sprouted remnants, as demonstrated in examples like (85), which are adapted from [Schuyler 2001](#).

- (85) a. PAM will read **THE ARTICLE** and **THE BOOK**, SUE will $\langle \text{VP read } t_T \rangle$
b. *PAM will read and **THE BOOK**, SUE will $\langle \text{VP read } t_T \rangle$

Stockwell (2020, 2024) similarly concludes from examples like (86), which come from Hardt 1993, that implicit agents do not contribute to appropriate antecedents for ellipsis.

- (86) a. ?The information was released by **SOMEONE** but
 GORBACHEV didn't $\langle_{VP}$ ~~release the information~~ $\rangle$
 b. *The information was released but **GORBACHEV** didn't $\langle_{VP}$ ~~release the information~~ $\rangle$

For both of these authors, the relevant contrast arises, at least in part, from the inability of an implicit argument to either be or provide a suitable alternative to the focused remnant.

This is an interpretation of the facts that is consistent with independent observations about implicit arguments outside the domain of ellipsis. The calculation of scalar implicatures, for instance, is commonly thought to involve the comparison of alternatives that are invoked by scalar expressions, including the quantifier *some* (see [Horn 1989](#), [Katzir 2008](#)). Assertion of the utterance in (87a) validates a line of reasoning that licenses the inference of the negation of stronger, more informative alternatives, including that William didn't clean everything ([Grice 1989](#), et seq.). The absence of any such implicature from (87b) suggests that existential implicit arguments do not invoke alternatives.

- (87) a. William cleaned **something**.
Scalar Implicature : William didn't clean everything.
 b. William cleaned.
No Scalar Implicature

A similar point can be made with reference to additive *too*. As a focus sensitive particle, *too* is commonly claimed to introduce a presupposition that there exists a salient alternative to a focus-marked element in its scope (see [Ahn 2015](#), [Szabolsci 2017](#)). This presupposition is satisfied with *the article* in (88a). However, the implicit argument in (88b) fails to provide a distinct salient alternative to the remnant, leaving the presupposition of *too* unsatisfied.

- (88) a. Kim read **THE ARTICLE** and she read **THE NOVEL** too.
Satisfied Presupposition : Kim read something that is not the novel.
 b. #Kim read and she read **THE NOVEL** too.
Unsatisfied Presupposition : Kim read something that is not the novel.

What makes sprouting possible in (84), therefore, is not recovery of the first conjunct as the antecedent for ellipsis. I propose that the possibility for ellipsis reflects the ability to recover a QUD from the discourse in the way illustrated in section 4.1. In the example examined there, the QUD was proffered explicitly in the discourse. However, it is commonly recognized that QUDs may be raised and addressed all while remaining implicit in the discourse ([Carlson 1983](#), [Cooper et al. 2000](#)). Indeed, for [Roberts \(2012\)](#), this is estimated to be the more common situation.

Consider the exchange presented in (89), which is modeled on examples found in [Cooper et al. 2000](#).

- (89) A: What was Kim doing?
 B: She was reading.

$$\rightsquigarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{What was Kim reading?, When was Kim reading?,} \\ \text{Where was Kim reading?, With whom was Kim reading?} \\ \text{How long was Kim reading? , ...} \end{array} \right\}$$
 And before you ask, she was reading THE NOVEL.

Participant A explicitly proffers a QUD for which participant B provides a congruent answer. Participant B's utterance also seems to conversationally implicate a family of potential follow-up questions (see also [Büring 2003](#), [AnderBois 2011](#)). Given that Kim was reading, it is possible to pursue further lines of inquiry with regard to the details of Kim's reading, including the what, the when, the where of it, and more. The idea that such questions have been made salient in the discourse and are available to serve as the QUD is made clear by participant B's continuation. Participant B is, in fact, able to answer any of a number of salient questions without proffering

them explicitly.

- (90) B: ... And before you ask, she was reading $\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{the novel} \\ \text{during the movie} \\ \text{at the library} \\ \text{with Marcus} \\ \text{longer than she intended to read} \\ \dots \end{array} \right\}$

Given the variety of responses possible for Participant B, determining which of these possible follow-up questions serves as the subsequent QUD requires accommodation on the part of other participants. As Büring (2003) and Roberts (2012) point out, it is possible to accommodate an implicit QUD on the basis of the content and the focal structure of an utterance. Faced with the utterance *she was reading* THE NOVEL in (89), participant A will determine that this could only be a congruent answer for the discourse-salient question *What was Kim reading?*. Participant A is therefore forced to accommodate this question meaning as the QUD, and interpret participant B's utterance as anaphoric to it.

It is the same principle of accommodation that I am proposing guides the resolution of sprouted stripping. Example (91) again provides an abbreviated version of the representation and derivation for sprouted stripping in a coordination structure:

- (91) Kim was reading and probably $[[PD \text{ THE NOVEL } \text{Kim was reading } x] \sim P_4]$
- i. $[\text{Kim was reading}] \rightsquigarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} [QUD \text{ What was Kim reading?}]_4, \text{ When was Kim reading?}, \\ \text{Where was Kim reading, With whom was Kim reading?} \\ \text{How long was Kim reading?}, \dots \end{array} \right\}$
- ii. $[[QUD_4]]^o = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \mid x \in Alt(\text{what}) \}$
- iii. $[[PD]]^f = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \mid x \in Alt(\text{the novel}) \}$
- iii. $[[QUD_4]]^o \subseteq [[PD]]^f$, ellipsis is permitted.

In the same way as above, the assertion that *Kim was reading* evokes a family of follow up questions that can be pursued as the subsequent QUD. The content of the second conjunct, containing the focus marked remnant *the novel*, can be interpreted as part of a congruent answer to the question *What was Kim reading?*. This congruence is validated by $\sim$ given the anaphoric link this question meaning has with P_4 . Furthermore, the ordinary semantic value of the QUD—a discourse object with the meaning of question—is a subset of the focus semantic value of the material in the second conjunct. As such, the relevant redundancy relation is established and ellipsis within the second conjunct is permitted, as desired.

This analysis also comes with the desirable property, mentioned in section 3.1, that the remnant

of sprouting can be of various different categories with various different grammatical roles:

- (92) Kim was reading and probably $\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{the novel} \\ \text{during the movie} \\ \text{at the library} \\ \text{with Marcus} \\ \text{longer than she intended to read} \\ \dots \end{array} \right\}$

For any of the possible QUDs that are implicated by *Kim was reading*, they can be accommodated given an appropriate remnant. In all such cases, the accommodated QUD serves as the antecedent for stripping.

In sum, stripping can be licensed by anaphoricity to either the spoken content of an utterance or possibly implicit question meanings implicated in the discourse. Stripping in coordinate structures, in principle, can employ either of these strategies. However, as the preceding discussion has proposed, sprouting is only possible by way of accommodating a QUD antecedent.

5.2.2 Failing to make accommodations for sprouting

With the preceding discussion in hand, it is now possible to understand how the unavailability of sprouting in comparative stripping reflects the outright inability to license ellipsis.

- (93) *Kim was reading more carefully than THE NOVEL.

The idea being pursued is that, because the content of the comparative clause is Not-At-Issue with respect to the QUD, it is incapable of raising and being anaphoric to a QUD for the purpose of licensing ellipsis in the way we saw for coordinate structures. In conjunction with the inability for implicit arguments to provide suitable antecedents, the consequence is that no suitable antecedent for ellipsis can be felicitously recovered from the discourse when sprouted stripping targets a comparative clause.

Let us appreciate, first, that the spoken content in these configurations will fail to provide a suitable antecedent for ellipsis. The following example provides an abbreviated representation for sprouted stripping in a comparative clause that is based on the earlier representation in (81).

- (94) * $[_{CP}$ Kim was reading carefully $]_2$
 $[\text{more than } [_{PD} \text{ THE NOVEL } \text{Kim was reading } x \text{ carefully}] \sim P_2]$
- i. $[[\text{CP}_2]]^o = \text{that Kim was reading } d\text{-carefully}$
 - ii. $[[\text{PD}]]^f = \{ p : p = \text{that Kim was reading } x \text{ } d\text{-carefully} \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the novel}) \}$
 - iii. $[[\text{CP}_2]]^o \notin [[\text{FD}]]^f$, ellipsis is *not* permitted.

The spoken content is, again, not a proposition of the correct shape to satisfy the redundancy condition on ellipsis.

The recourse that was taken in the context of coordinate stripping above was to rely instead on an implicit QUD to provide an appropriate antecedent. The proposal is that this will not be a successful strategy for resolving the instances of sprouted stripping in comparatives. Recall that the diagnostics presented in section 4.2 point to the conclusion that the content of a comparative clause is not packaged in such a way that it can be felicitously interpreted as being relevant to the QUD; it is QUD Not-At-Issue content. It is this fact that distinguishes the content of comparative clauses from the content of conjuncts. Moreover, this is what I am proposing precludes the content of comparative clauses from accommodating a QUD antecedent for ellipsis.

This naturally raises the question of precisely why a Not-At-Issue status relative to the QUD should preclude antecedence by the QUD for ellipsis. Toward an answer to this question, I would note that establishing the content of the comparative clause as QUD Not-At-Issue is consistent with the claim that this material is interpreted as presupposed content (Simons et al. 2010, Beaver et al. 2017). As explicated by Aravind & Hackl (2017), the presupposed status of some content will necessarily conflict with a requirement for that same content to raise and address a QUD. After all, accommodating some presupposed content requires accepting it as an answer to its congruent question, thus signaling that question as being resolved. Because the QUD is, by definition, an unresolved question, requiring presupposed content to raise and address the QUD places conflicting requirements on the discourse.

With that said, to the extent that the content of a comparative clause is presupposed information, it is expected that, in addition to behaviors observed in section 4.2, this material should generally behave like projective content. It should survive in the context of negation, modals, and questions like in (95):

- (95)
- a. It's not the case that Kim was reading the article more carefully than she was reading the novel.
 - b. It's possible that Kim was reading the article the article more carefully than she was reading the novel.
 - c. Was Kim reading the article the article more carefully than she was reading the novel?

Each of these examples in fact presupposes that that Kim was reading the novel with some degree of carefulness.

Consider, in this light, how we correctly predict that an instance of sprouted stripping will not successfully accommodate a QUD as the antecedent for ellipsis:

(96) * $\llbracket$ Kim was reading carefully $\rrbracket$

more than $\llbracket$ PD THE NOVEL ~~Kim was reading x carefully~~ $\rrbracket \sim P_{??}$ $\rrbracket$

- i. $\llbracket$ Kim was reading d -carefully $\rrbracket \rightsquigarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{What was Kim reading } d\text{-carefully?}, \\ \text{When was Kim reading } d\text{-carefully?}, \\ \text{Where was Kim reading } d\text{-carefully?}, \\ \text{With whom was Kim reading } d\text{-carefully?}, \\ \dots \end{array} \right\}$
- $\llbracket$ AC $\rrbracket^o = ??$
- ii. $\llbracket$ PD $\rrbracket^f = \{p : \text{that Kim read } x \text{ carefully} \mid x \in D_e\}$
- iii. $\llbracket$ AC $\rrbracket^o \not\subseteq \llbracket$ PD $\rrbracket^f$, ellipsis is *not* licensed.

We can assume that, in the same way as above, uttering *Kim was reading carefully* will implicate a family of potential follow-up questions. Among these will be the question *What was Kim reading carefully?* to which the content of the comparative clause offers a congruent answer. The operative difference that has been motivated for the case at hand is that the content of the comparative clause is QUD Not-At-Issue. As suggested immediately above, this means that the remnant *the novel* cannot felicitously signal an intent to raise and resolve a QUD. The desired result is that the question meaning *What was Kim reading carefully?* is not felicitously established as the QUD. This has the knock-on effect that the variable argument P of $\sim$ fails to establish an anaphoric link with a suitable discourse antecedent that satisfies the redundancy condition on ellipsis. Consequently, Ellipsis is not licensed in this configuration, exactly as desired.

This analysis rests heavily on two claims. The first is that the QUD is not a recoverable antecedent for the purpose of licensing ellipsis. This can be seen as a reflection of the observations above and in section 4.2 that the content of comparative clauses is not appropriately packaged in a way to be construed as addressing the QUD. Part of this inappropriate packaging is the fact that this material contains presupposed information. It is noteworthy therefore, that accommodation of an antecedent is disrupted by the presuppositions of the spoken content, as opposed to being facilitated by them (cf. Barros & Kotek 2019 and Stockwell 2024).

The second claim that is instrumental to the analysis at hand is that implicit arguments do not contribute to well-formed antecedents for ellipsis. Independent evidence to this effect was provided in section 5.2.1. However, it must also be true that the entailments of clauses containing implicit arguments are insufficient for the purposes of licensing ellipsis. Let us assume, following Fox (2000) et seq., that the entailment that Kim read something carefully is calculated given the content of the matrix clause in (96). The ungrammaticality of that example suggests that an object with this meaning is not sufficient for licensing sprouting in comparative constructions. This in turn suggests that it is not the entailments of the first conjunct that are responsible for licensing sprouting in the grammatical cases of sprouted stripping in coordination structures. Thus, we

encounter a problem familiar from section 3.2 whereby an imaginable alternative does not predict the contrast between the two types of structures.

6 Extending the analysis to other stripping operations

This final substantive section investigates a prediction of the analysis presented above. To the extent that some domain permits stripping, the expectation should be that it will permit sprouting only if that domain is At-Issue with respect to the QUD. We will test this prediction in two domains: temporal adverbial clauses and *like*-clauses. While both constructions have been argued to be reduced via a stripping-like operation, neither permits sprouting. This coincides, again, with the Not-At-Issue status and presupposed status of the content embedded in these constructions. Thus, it is again an inability to trigger the accommodation of and address a QUD that precludes the identification of an acceptable antecedent for ellipsis.

6.1 Stripping in temporal adverbial clauses

Non-coordinate stripping has also been proposed as a mechanism for the reduction of temporal adverbial clauses introduced by *before* and *after*. A relevant pair of examples is provided in (97):

- (97) a. Kim read THE ARTICLE after she read THE NOVEL.
 b. Kim read THE ARTICLE after ~~Kim read~~ THE NOVEL.

This is an idea that can be traced back to Geis (1970). However, more explicit proposals regarding the reduction mechanism have subsequently been put forward by Larson (1987), Thompson (2005) and Overfelt (2021).²⁵

Overfelt (2021) argues that many of the indicators for clausal ellipsis that are observed for comparative stripping, and which were presented in section 2, are also observed for examples like (97b). This is taken to motivate an analysis that employs the same kind of stripping derivation that we have seen in coordinate and comparative constructions.²⁶

- (98) Kim read THE ARTICLE [after THE NOVEL₁ $\langle$ ~~Kim read~~ t_1 $\rangle$]
- 

The examples above serve to demonstrate that stripping in temporal adverbial clauses is acceptable when the remnant is paired with an overt correlate in the matrix clause. Of interest here

²⁵Just as with comparative clauses, reduced temporal adverbial clauses have been given direct analyses, whereby the phrasal constituent combines directly with the temporal connective (Penka & von Stechow 2011).

²⁶For the sake of accuracy, Overfelt (2021) actually proposes that temporal adverbials targeted for stripping are adjoined at the level of the vP and embed a vP complement. This makes the relevant stripping operation similar to previous proposals by Pancheva (2009) for comparatives and by Weir (2014b) for *why*-stripping.

is the fact that stripping in temporal adverbial clauses, like comparative clauses, does not permit sprouted remnants:

- (99) a. Kim read (for another hour) after she read **THE NOVEL**.
b. *Kim read (for another hour) after **THE NOVEL**.

Importantly, this is a case again where it can be demonstrated that the ungrammaticality of (99b) reflects an inability to license ellipsis. The acceptability of the unreduced example in (99a) suggests that nothing in principle precludes the derivation or representation of the source structure for ellipsis.

Furthermore, like comparative clauses, the content of temporal adverbial clauses also appears to be packaged in such a way that it cannot felicitously be construed as content that is relevant to the QUD. This is a conclusion about temporal adverbial clauses that [Gor & Syrett \(2019\)](#) reach independently on the basis of the disjoint reference effects associated with Condition C. Concerning the diagnostics presented in section 4.2, we find that it is not possible to construe the content of a temporal adverbial clause as the sole content relevant to answering the QUD.

- (100) A: What did Kim read?
B: #Kim worked on her article after she read A NOVEL.

As [Gor & Syrett \(2019\)](#) also note, such behavior is in line with the standard view of the content of temporal adverbial clauses as presupposed information, a claim made as early as [Hooper & Thompson 1973](#). The examples below show that the proposition that Kim read a novel survives in the relevant contexts:

- (101) a. It's not the case that Kim read the article after she read the novel.
b. It's possible that Kim read the article after she read the novel.
c. Did Kim read the article after she read the novel?

In light of these observations and given the analysis presented in the previous section, the lack of sprouting stripping in temporal adverbial clauses is entirely expected. For the same reasons that have been offered above, the implicit argument in the matrix clause will not contribute to a suitable antecedent for the purpose of establishing redundancy for ellipsis.²⁷

²⁷For reasons similar to those put forward for comparative clauses, there is evidence for an operator-variable chain inside temporal adverbial clauses that finds a parallel relationship in the matrix clause ([Geis 1970](#), [Larson 1987](#), [Overfelt 2021](#)). I include the tail of these chains (*at t*) in the examples in the text for the sake of comparison with the analysis of comparatives.

- (102) * $[\text{CP Kim read at } t]_2$ after $[[\text{PD THE NOVEL } \text{Kim read } x \text{ at } t] \sim P_2]$
- i. $\llbracket \text{CP}_2 \rrbracket^o = \text{that Kim read at } t$
 - ii. $\llbracket \text{PD} \rrbracket^f = \{ p : \text{that Kim read } x \text{ at } t \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the novel}) \}$
 - iii. $\llbracket \text{CP}_2 \rrbracket^o \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{PD} \rrbracket^f$, ellipsis is *not* licensed.

Moreover, the QUD Not-At-Issue status of the content of the temporal adverbial clause means that it cannot be construed as content that is relevant to the QUD. Assuming that the content of the matrix clause implicates a family of following up question, the remnant is part of discourse content that cannot felicitously signal the need to accommodate one of these as the subsequent QUD.

- (103) * $[\text{Kim read at } t]$ after $[[\text{PD THE NOVEL } \text{Kim read } x \text{ at } t] \sim P_{??}]$
- i. $[\text{Kim read at } t] \rightsquigarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{What did Kim read at } t?, \\ \text{Where did Kim read at } t?, \\ \text{With whom did Kim read at } t?, \\ \text{Why did Kim read at } t?, \\ \dots \end{array} \right\}$
 - ii. $\llbracket \text{AC} \rrbracket^o = ??$
 - iii. $\llbracket \text{FD} \rrbracket^f = \{ p : \text{that Kim read } x \text{ at } t \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{the novel}) \}$
 - iii. $\llbracket \text{AC} \rrbracket^o \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{FD} \rrbracket^f$, ellipsis is *not* licensed.

Because no explicitly offered material in the discourse provides a suitable antecedent and because no suitable QUD antecedent can be felicitously accommodated, sprouted stripping cannot be licensed in a temporal adverbial clause.

6.2 Stripping in *like*-clauses

Yoshida (2013) provides evidence—again, much like what has been compiled in section 2—that *like*-clauses of the kind in (104) can be reduced by stripping.

- (104) a. MICHAEL must not dance like FIONA dances.
b. MICHAEL must not dance like Fiona ~~dances~~.

(adapted from Yoshida 2013:305, (1))

In the same way as we have seen throughout, this treatment has the phrasal remnant of the stripping operation escape ellipsis by way of movement to the edge of the embedded clause.²⁸ The example in (105) provides a familiar derivation and representation:

²⁸Once again, for the sake of accuracy, Yoshida (2013) in fact argues that reduced *like*-clauses can be adjoined to various positions on the verbal spine and contain an elided TP constituent.

- (105) Kim (rarely) reads **ARTICLES** [like **NOVELS**₁ $\langle$ ~~Kim reads t_1~~ $\rangle$]

The possibility of sprouting in reduced *like*-clauses is discussed briefly in reference to the following sets of examples. The judgements are as presented in Yoshida (2013:308, (11)).

- (106) a. Michael (hatefully) served dinner **to CARLA**
like **to GILROY** $\langle$ ~~he served dinner~~ t_T $\rangle$
b. Michael (hatefully) served dinner **to CARLA**
like **GILROY** $\langle$ ~~he served dinner to~~ t_T $\rangle$
- (107) a. Michael (hatefully) served dinner like **to GILROY** $\langle$ ~~he served dinner~~ t_T $\rangle$
b. *Michael (hatefully) served dinner like **GILROY** $\langle$ ~~he served dinner to~~ t_T $\rangle$

The examples of stripping in (106) with an overt correlate for the remnant set the baseline. These are to be contrasted with the examples of sprouting in (107). For [Yoshida \(2013\)](#), the ban against preposition-stranding in the contrast between the examples in (108) serves as evidence that *like*-clauses are reduced by clausal ellipsis, given the similar behavior observed in sluicing.

To my ear, there is indeed a contrast between the examples in (107) in the stated direction. However, there is still a contrast between the sprouting example in (107a) and the example in (106a). Sprouting, for me, is degraded at best in this example and marginal at worst. Examples like (108) below, which can be contrasted with example (105), allow for clearer intuitions. In such cases, with a direct object remnant, sprouting clearly results in ungrammaticality. Importantly, the variant of this example without ellipsis is grammatical.

- (108) a. Kim (rarely) reads like she reads **NOVELS**.
b. *Kim (rarely) reads like **NOVELS** $\langle$ Kim was reading t_i $\rangle$

To the extent that the content of *like*-clauses behaves like QUD Not-At-Issue content, the lack of sprouting observe in examples like (108) would be entirely expected. As shown in (109), content packaged within a *like*-clause fails to serve as content that solely provides the answer to a QUD.

- (109) A: What does Kim read?
B: #Kim reads like she reads NOVELS.

This again coincides with the observation that the content of the *like*-clause is presupposed material. The proposition that Kim reads novels survives in the context of negation, modals, and questions, as illustrated below:

- (110) a. It's not the case that Kim reads articles like she reads novels.
 b. It's possible that Kim reads articles like she reads novels.
 c. Does Kim read articles like she reads novels?

The explanation for the restriction on sprouting will hopefully be familiar at this point. The content of the matrix clause will not offer a suitable antecedent for licensing ellipsis because of the implicit argument serving as the correlate for the remnant.²⁹

- (111) * $[\text{CP Kim reads as } m]_2$ like $[[\text{PD NOVELS}_1 \text{ ~~Kim reads } x_1 \text{ as } m]~~$ $\sim P_2]$
- i. $[\text{CP}_2]^0 = \text{that Kim reads as } m$
 - ii. $[\text{PD}]^f = \{ p : \text{that Kim reads } x \text{ as } m \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{novels}) \}$
 - iii. $[\text{CP}_2]^0 \not\subseteq [\text{PD}]^f$, ellipsis is *not* licensed.

The fact that the content of the *like*-clause is QUD Not-At-Issue material means, once again, that the remnant of the ellipsis operation is incapable of felicitously raising or addressing a QUD to serve as an antecedent; see (112):

- (112) * $[\text{Kim reads as } m]$ like $[[\text{FD NOVELS}_1 \text{ ~~Kim reads } x_1 \text{ as } m]~~$ $\sim P_{??}]$
- i. $[\text{Kim reads as } m] \rightsquigarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{What does Kim read as } m?, \\ \text{Where does Kim read as } m?, \\ \text{With whom does Kim read as } m?, \\ \text{Why does Kim read as } m?, \\ \dots \end{array} \right\}$
 - ii. $[\text{AC}]^0 = ??$
 - iii. $[\text{FD}]^f = \{ p : \text{that Kim reads } x \text{ as } m \mid x \in \text{Alt}(\text{novels}) \}$
 - iii. $[\text{AC}]^0 \not\subseteq [\text{FD}]^f$, ellipsis is *not* licensed.

Therefore, in exactly the same way as we have seen for comparative clauses and temporal adverbial clauses, sprouted stripping cannot be licensed as a consequence of the inability to recover or accommodate and antecedent for ellipsis.

7 Conclusion

The primary empirical focus of the manuscript has been the unavailability of sprouted stripping in comparative clauses. This is in contrast to coordination structures containing *and* and *but*,

²⁹Though it is not included Yoshida 2013, I believe there is reason to assume that *like*-clause constructions contain parallel operator-variable chains of the type found with standard comparatives and temporal adverbial clauses. I include the tails of these chains (*as m(anner)*) here for the sake of comparison. However, the analysis does not depend on this decision.

which otherwise permit sprouted stripping. The analysis argued that what makes those domains that preclude sprouting a natural class is the Not-At-Issue-ness of their propositional content with respect to the QUD. This made it possible to claim that sprouted stripping requires an anaphoric link to an accommodated QUD in the discourse, which is precluded by the discourse status of the content embedded by these structures. Paired with the claim that implicit arguments do not contribute to suitable antecedents for ellipsis, the inability to sprout a remnant specifically in a comparative clause, was the result of the inability to license ellipsis.

The analysis was built upon a theory of ellipsis licensing that, in principle, permits stripping to recover an antecedent from either the spoken content of an utterance or an implicit QUD. This type of flexibility in the resolution of ellipsis is expected given a theory of ellipsis licensing that employs the system of focus interpretation proposed by [Rooth \(1992a,b\)](#). Future research might investigate whether this offers utility in understanding other varieties of ellipsis beyond stripping. It must also fall to future research to identify the constraints on this proposed flexibility in antecedent recovery. However, to the extent that the QUD serves as one of the possible sources for antecedents, the expectation is that the relevant constraints should coincide with the constraints on anaphoricity to QUDs. The previous discussion has attempted to show that, at least in the domain of sprouting, this appears to be the case.

The proposed analysis also rested heavily on a concept of antecedent accommodation that deviates in non-trivial ways from what is arguably the baseline theory of accommodation that originates with [Fox 1999, 2000](#). Accommodation in that line of research is constrained to content that is entailed or presupposed by previously spoken material, or is restricted to the reuse of the spoken material. The proposal advanced in the manuscript builds instead on an influential line of research proposing that resolving the meaning of an ellipsis site might involve accommodating a question meaning in the discourse ([Ginzburg & Sag 2001](#), et seq.). This made it possible to accommodate antecedents from question meanings that are merely conversationally implicated in the discourse, not entailed nor presupposed. It of course remains to be demonstrated that this adjustment to the constraints on accommodation does not overgenerate. However, the expectation is that constraints built into the QUD-model will coincide with the possibility of accommodating antecedents for ellipsis. Again, the previous discussion of stripping suggests that this is the case.

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